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DRAGO

Diamantino Pedro Azevedo

(ah-zeh-VAY-doh)

Minister of Mineral Resources, Petroleum, and Gas
Republic of Angola

Addressed as: **Excellency** | Office held since: **Sept 2017**

Diamantino Pedro Azevedo, a technocrat with a strong background in mining engineering, favors bold action and hands-on leadership to advance his objectives in the petroleum sector.

- **Principled Decisions**
  Azevedo is certain about what is right for Angola, announcing Angola's departure from OPEC in December 2023 because his country "gains nothing by remaining in the organization" and cutting ties with Russian diamond giant Alrosa in November 2024 due to EU sanctions.

- **High Expectations**
  He is clear about his expectations for Angola's energy security and the role of foreign governments and oil companies to "be partners in our development, not just extracting our resources."

While Azevedo routinely demands more efficiency in the petroleum and mineral sectors, he appears highly attuned to political sensitivities; he has been careful to avoid layoffs or unduly outsource work to foreign workers and companies.

WHY THEY MATTER

As the driving force behind Angola's energy policy, Azevedo plays a pivotal role in shaping the investment climate for foreign oil and mining companies.

- **Backing Oil and Gas**
  While Azevedo's focus is on diversifying Angola's economy beyond petroleum, he has stressed that oil and gas "will still be important for decades to come." He wants to maintain production above one million barrels per day with exploration and block development to increase output.

- **Signaling Future Privatization**
  He says Angola will privatize up to 30 percent of Sonangol, the state-owned oil company, when it is "a true well operating company...because so far it operates only 2 percent of wells, and the medium-term target is 10 percent."

Azevedo believes in the potential of natural resources to benefit both Angola and international partners. He has stated, "If we work together with our people and collaborate with our neighbors, we will achieve great things."

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MEETING WITH THEM

Azevedo is focused on future plans, strategies, and goals for Angola's energy sector, and he usually seeks to win over his interlocutors with his vision for collaboration and mutually beneficial outcomes.

- **Rejecting Unjust Deals**
  Azevedo emphasizes Angola's commitment to working with others, but he is firm about his expectations and respectfully shares what his government will not accept, including what he deems as unjust, unreasonable, or inequitable.

- **Promoting Win-Win Outcomes**
  In 2022, he asked for “win-win” cooperation from potential British mining partners while warning that they should not talk about an energy transition without “hydrocarbons and other mineral resources.”

Azevedo demands a lot from himself, counterparts, and colleagues, regularly pressing for more action (“don’t stay normal”) and committing himself to be more engaged to realize the government’s goals.

ON THEIR MIND

- **Chevron Sells Oil Blocks**
  Chevron in mid-March indicated it would sell its interests in two offshore Angola oil blocks for a base consideration of $260 million to Energean, a Mediterranean-focused gas producer.

- **Sonangol seeks $4.8 billion loan from China**
  Angola's state oil company Sonangol is talking to Chinese financial institutions to secure a $4.8 billion loan to partly finance the construction of a new refinery in the Atlantic sea port of Lobito. If completed, it will mark the first borrowing from China by Angola since 2017.

- **U.S. Support for Lobito Corridor**
  The U.S. International Development Finance Corporation in December signed a USD$553 million loan with a consortium of firms for the refurbishment of an Angolan railway line - part of the Lobito critical minerals corridor.

- **Pope to travel to Angola**
  The Vatican's ambassador to Angola announced that Pope Leo XIV will travel to Angola in April, calling it an opportunity “to rediscover the values that guide the Angolan people, and that those values can be shared with the diverse communities that live and work throughout the world."

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NETWORK

Azevedo maintains a pragmatic approach to international relations, balancing relationships with traditional Western partners and emerging powers like China. Even while strengthening ties with China, he has been quick to underline Angola's commitment to diversify its international partnerships.

The Minister has significantly expanded Angola's engagement with the United States. In June 2025, he presided over the signing of Sonangol-MIT partnership agreements, and he met with U.S. Secretary of Energy Chris Wright to discuss cooperation in oil, gas, critical minerals, and renewables. The Trump administration's continuation of Lobito Corridor financing has reinforced U.S.-Angola ties.

Azevedo enjoys a close working relationship with President João Lourenço, who has repeatedly reappointed him and awarded him the Commemorative Medal for the 50th Anniversary of National Independence in July 2025—signaling deep trust in his management of the energy sector.

As a member of the ruling MPLA party, Azevedo is well-connected and adroitly managed the transition between President José Eduardo dos Santos and Lourenço. He closely collaborates with Sebastião Gaspar Martins, Sonangol CEO, on key projects—including Sonangol's recent push to diversify into critical minerals.

CONTROVERSIES

While Azevedo has largely avoided personal controversies, his policies have faced some criticism.

- **Gripes about Reforms**
  His push for rapid sector reforms and emphasis on local content have occasionally caused friction with international oil companies, some of which have found the pace of change challenging to navigate. Critics argue Angola's commodity-dependent economy has yet to deliver tangible benefits for ordinary citizens despite years of reform promises.

- **Fuel Subsidy Protests**
  In late July 2025, Angola experienced some of its worst civil unrest in decades after the government cut fuel subsidies. The protests—which included looting, burning tyres, and violent clashes—were driven by frustration over rising living costs and perceptions that ordinary Angolans are not benefiting from the country's oil wealth.

Azevedo's decision to withdraw Angola from OPEC in December 2023 sparked debate both domestically and internationally. Critics have argued the move might isolate Angola from important international oil market dynamics, while supporters view it as a necessary step to gain greater control over national oil production.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Mineral Resources, Petroleum, and Gas**, Republic of Angola (2017 to present)
- **Chairman of the Board of Directors**, FERRANGOL (2006 to 2017)
- **Managing Director**, South and East African Mining Center (SEAMIC) (2002 to 2006)
- **National Director of International Relations**, Ministry of Geology and Mines (1997 to 2002)
- **Professor**, Agostinho Neto University (1998 to 2017)

BIO

Azevedo, who grew up during Angola's struggle for independence and the early years of civil war, was among the first students at the National Institute of Petroleum. Born on July 12, 1963, his home province of Cuanza Sul was badly affected during the war, with UNITA opening its central front there. He was 12 when the war started and 39 when it ended.

- **Engineering Background**
  Azevedo studied Geology at Agostinho Neto University. He holds a master's degree in mining engineering from the Freiberg Mining Academy in Germany (1991) and a PhD in Mining Engineering from the Technical University of Berlin (1997).

- **German Influence**
  His time in Germany almost certainly shaped his technical approach and global outlook. He has authored and contributed to several articles and reports related to Angola's energy and mining sectors.

Married with two children, Azevedo keeps his family life private. He speaks Portuguese, English, and German fluently.

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